PortableTAK Quick Start

Your TAK server on a USB drive. Plug it into an OpenMANET node, a Windows computer or a Mac.

> **Before you start:** this drive has already been set up with a server name, an **administrator password** (dashboard sign-in) and a **client password** (phones use it to enroll). You need those two passwords.
> **Blank drive?** The first time it starts on Windows, it asks you for the server name and both passwords.

A. On an OpenMANET node (no screen)

1. With the node powered on, plug the drive into a **blue USB 3 port**.
2. Wait **3–5 minutes**. The first start on a new node takes longer while it sets itself up for that node.
3. Connect your phone or laptop to the node's Wi-Fi.
4. Scan the QR code (or open `https://10.41.254.1:8444`). Your browser warns about the certificate the first time: choose **Advanced** → **Continue**.
5. Sign in as `administrator` with the administrator password.

Scan to open the dashboard

B. On a Windows computer

1. Plug in the drive. Open it in File Explorer and double-click **Start PortableTAK (Windows)**.
2. Click **Yes** when Windows asks for permission. The first time on a computer, it installs what it needs (and may ask to restart once; then double-click it again).
3. The dashboard opens in your browser. The window shows **this computer's address** for phones and WinTAK.
4. The drive disappears from File Explorer while the server runs. That is normal.
5. To finish, double-click **Stop PortableTAK** on the desktop, wait for "You can remove the drive now", then unplug.

Needs Windows 11 (22H2 or newer). Phones and WinTAK must be on the same network as the computer.

C. On a Mac (Apple Silicon)

1. One time: install QEMU (in Terminal: `brew install qemu`).
2. Plug in the drive and double-click **Start PortableTAK (Mac)** on the PORTABLETAK volume. Enter your Mac password when asked.
3. The dashboard opens. The window shows **this Mac's address** for phones and WinTAK. If macOS asks whether qemu may accept incoming connections, click **Allow**.
4. To finish, press **Return** in that window (or double-click **Stop PortableTAK** on the Desktop), then eject and unplug.

D. Add a phone (ATAK, iTAK) or WinTAK

1. In the dashboard open **Users** → **Create User**, one user per person. (In the TAK app, give every device its own **callsign**.)
2. Under **Manage User / Download Setup Package**, choose how to connect the device:
   - **ATAK: ATAK Package**, then import it in ATAK (Import → Local SD). **WinTAK: WinTAK Setup**.
   - **iTAK: iTAK Package**, opened in iTAK. For use over cellular, also import the **iTAK Remote Package** (iTAK uses one server per package).
   - **QR: ATAK QR Setup** / **iTAK QR Setup**, scanned in the TAK app. iPhone, once first: **iPhone Trust Profile (for QR)** in Client Setup (open it in Safari on the iPhone), install it, then turn on full trust in Settings → General → About → Certificate Trust Settings (without this switch iTAK says "error connecting to the server"). ATAK must trust the server first: import the **ATAK Trust Package (for QR)** from Client Setup once per phone. With remote access set up, ATAK QR Setup also adds the "(Tailscale)" server for cellular.
3. The connection turns **green** in the TAK app when connected.

E. Before unplugging the drive

Node: press **Safe Remove** in the dashboard (Server section) and wait for "safe to remove". **Windows / Mac:** double-click **Stop PortableTAK** on the desktop (the dashboard's *Stop Server* only pauses the TAK services; it does not release the drive). If power is lost, PortableTAK checks and repairs the drive by itself on the next start.

F. Use it over cellular (remote access)

Lets phones reach the server from anywhere with internet. It uses **Tailscale**, a free private network. Do this once per server; it needs an internet connection on the server side.

1. Make a Tailscale account at `tailscale.com` (free). Use the same account everywhere below.

2. Connect the drive to Tailscale (the same on a node, Windows or Mac; the server needs internet): Dashboard → **Remote Access** → **Enable remote access** → open the link shown → sign in → **Connect**. Back in the dashboard press **Finish setup** and wait about 2 minutes. The drive keeps this Tailscale address wherever it runs, so you only do this once. The computer does not need the Tailscale app.

3. On each phone: install the **Tailscale** app from the App Store / Play Store, sign in with the **same account**, and switch it **on** (allow the VPN when asked).

4. Set up each phone after step 2 (Users → your user): **ATAK QR Setup** or the **ATAK Package** on Android: either one gives the phone two servers, "*server name* (Wi-Fi)" or the address, and "*server name* (Tailscale)". On iPhone import the **iTAK Remote Package** (or scan **iTAK QR Setup** with "Phone is on: Tailscale") as well as the normal one. Phones set up before step 2 need setting up again.

5. Test: turn the phone's Wi-Fi off. With Tailscale on, the server connection turns green over cellular.

6. Open the dashboard from anywhere: on any phone or laptop with the Tailscale app **on** (same account), open `https://<Tailscale address>:8444`, for example `https://100.102.110.115:8444`. The address is shown under **Remote Access** and is the same wherever the drive runs: write it down. Accept the browser warning (**Advanced** → **Proceed**), then sign in as on Wi-Fi.

> Not working? The Tailscale app must be **on** and signed in to the same account on the phone, the server side must have internet, and the phone must have the new package.

> More help: **PortableTAK Quick Reference** (addresses, ports, common tasks) and **PortableTAK Setup and Troubleshooting Guide** (everything in detail).